Leverkusen 2023/24: Opposition Report

Oct 19, 2026 ·

Summary

Question: should we press Leverkusen high, and how? How do we attack them?

Answer: press their build-up high while the score is level, but not when we are chasing the game. Block passes into Xhaka at all times. With the ball, carry it out of their press, attack the flanks and make set pieces count.

Recommendations

1. **Press high while the score is level.** Chances won and conceded broke even, and their build-ups reaching the final third fell from 60% to 38%.
2. **Drop into a compact block when chasing.** Pressing high while behind (Leverkusen leading) gave up 2.8 xG per 100 pressed build-ups, against 1.2 at level scores. xG (expected goals) measures chance quality: 1.0 xG is one goal's worth of chances.
3. **Block passes into Xhaka.** With a player within 6m of him when he receives, his forward passes (10+ yards) drop from 16% to under 4%.
4. **Secure the ball after winning it.** Bochum won it back as often as Bayern but gave it straight back.
5. **With the ball: carry it out, go wide, rehearse set pieces.** Set pieces produced 10 of the 24 non-penalty goals they conceded.
6. **Stay switched on to the end.** Their 18 goals from the 80th minute won them 12 points.

All 34 Leverkusen Bundesliga matches, 2023/24 (StatsBomb open data). Matches are labelled from the opponent's side: (H) = at the opponent's ground, (A) = at Leverkusen, opponent's goals first. Key findings were checked against video (Video A–F).

How Leverkusen build up

Leverkusen build through Xhaka and their centre-backs, rarely lose the ball early, and are most dangerous when they exit through the left half-space or by carrying the ball out.

- **Shape:** mostly 3-4-2-1. Xhaka is the hub: he makes or receives 27% of all completed own-half passes, followed by Tah (25%) and Tapsoba (20%). The busiest link is Xhaka-Tah, 12 passes per match.
- **Left-sided first phase:** Grimaldo, the left wing-back, makes or receives 13% of own-half passes; Frimpong on the right only 5%. Frimpong stays high, near halfway, while the right side of the first phase goes through the right centre-back (Kossonou, 13%).

Frimpong is still a regular target once the ball leaves their third (59 exit receptions), so expect the build-up down their left and the outlet ball to him on the right.

- **Security:** from 1,121 build-ups in their own third, they lost the ball in that third only 3.4% of the time. 55% reached the final third.
- **Exits:** they leave their third evenly across all five channels (18-23% each), so there is no single weak side to show them to. Xhaka, Wirtz and Grimaldo receive most exits.
- **Where the threat is:** measured by Expected Threat (how much each exit raised their chance of scoring), the left half-space is the most dangerous exit and the wings the least. Carries out of the third are more dangerous than short passes, and 78% of them reach the final third.
- **Under pressure:** against Bayern, the build-up dropped about 6 yards deeper, Tapsoba became the hub (31% of passes, up from 20%), the goalkeeper was used more, and Wirtz dropped in to help (17% of passes, up from 9%).

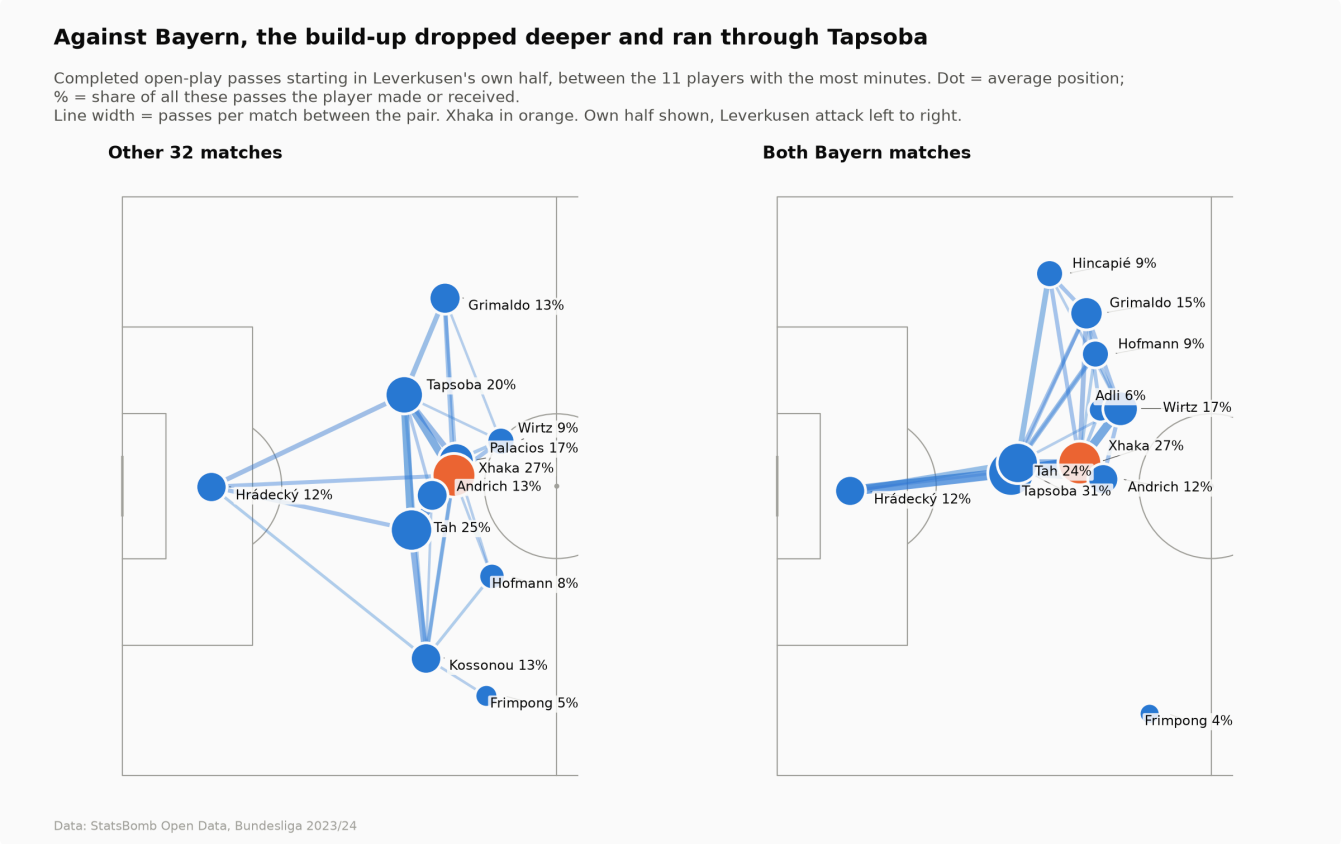


Figure 1. Build-up pass network for the 11 players with the most minutes: the other 32 matches vs both Bayern matches.

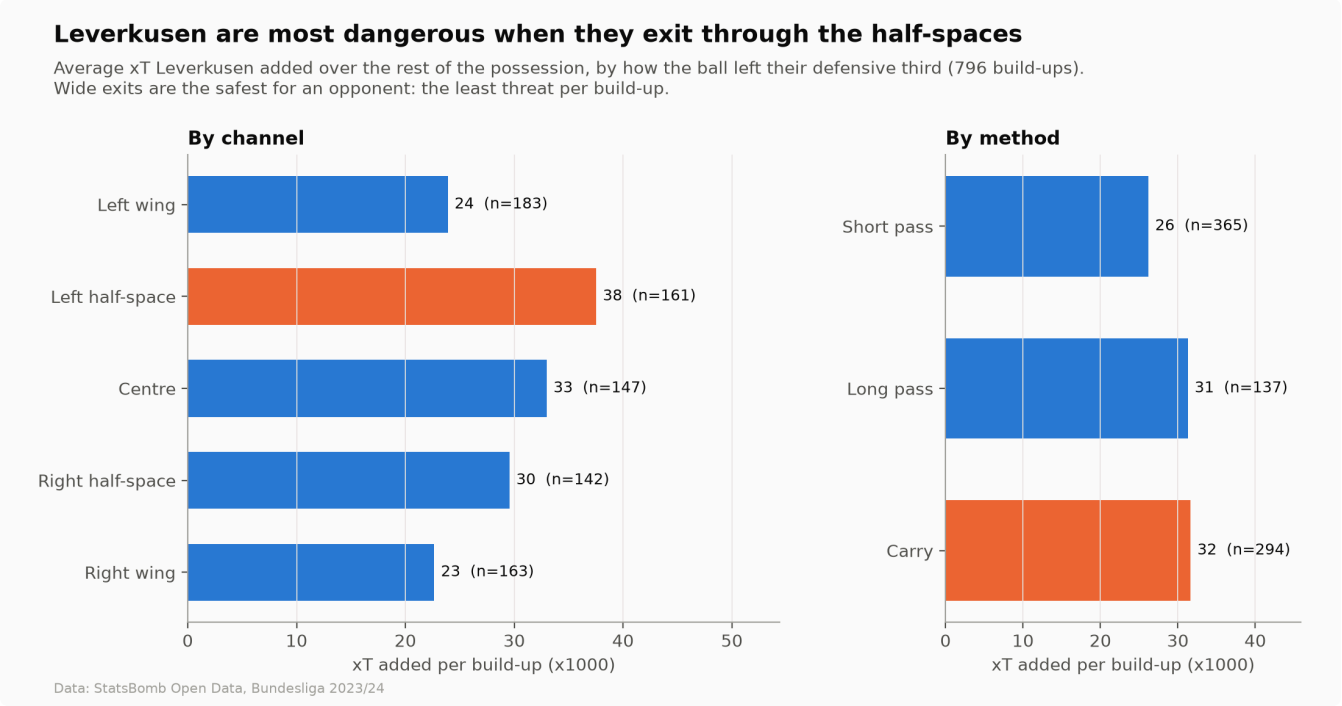


Figure 2. Threat added per build-up (Expected Threat), by exit channel and by whether the ball was passed or carried out of their defensive third.

What happens when they are pressed

Pressing high stops Leverkusen getting up the pitch. But it only paid off when the press won the ball and kept it.

The higher an opponent pressed, the less often Leverkusen reached the final third. Across the 34 matches the link is strong (correlation -0.74; 90% interval -0.84 to -0.61). Bayern held them to their two lowest rates of the season: 30% and 26%, against a usual 56%.

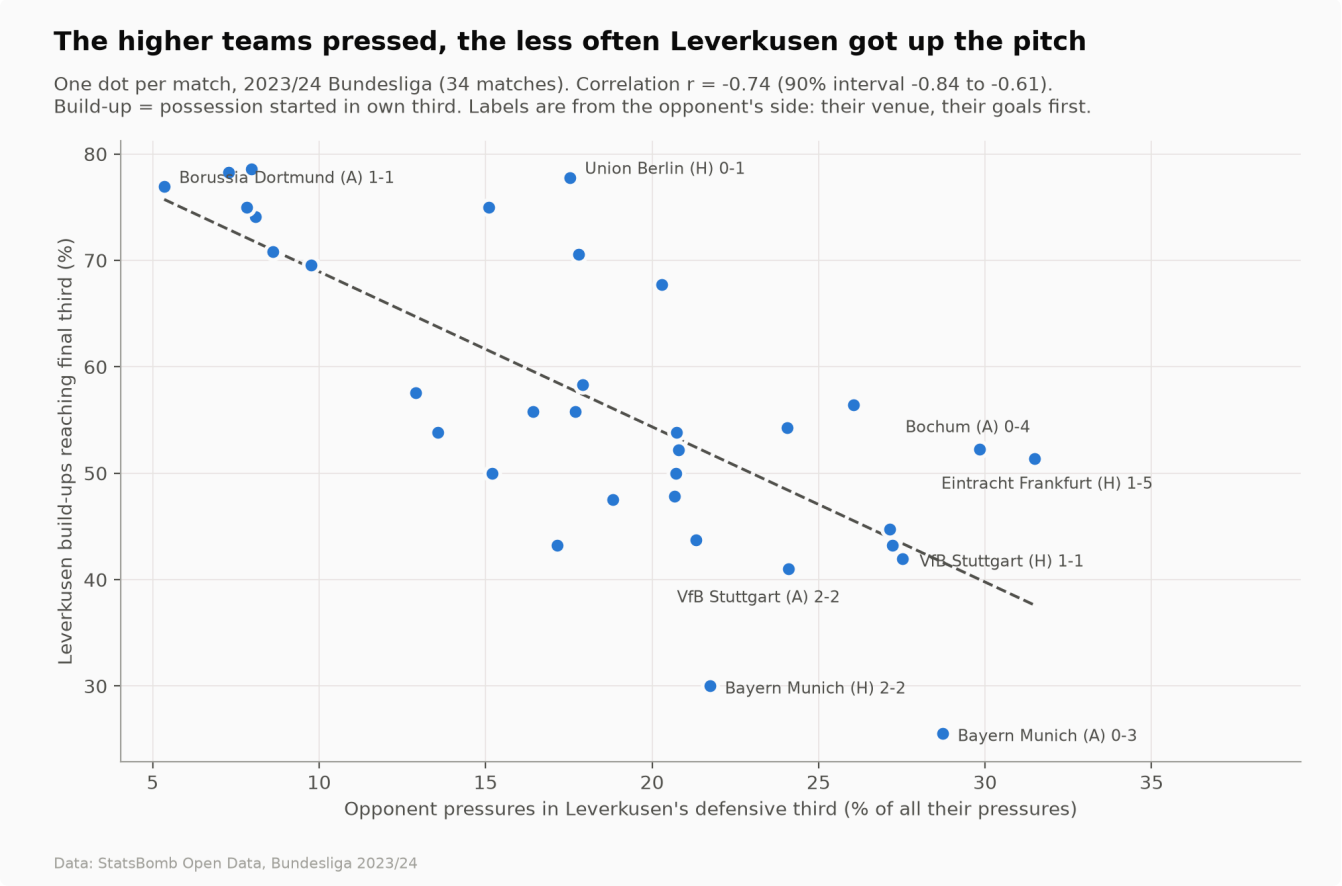


Figure 3. Opponent press height vs how often Leverkusen reached the final third, one dot per match.

Four teams pressed Leverkusen highest. All four won the ball back more often than the typical opponent. The difference was whether they kept it.

	Bayern (H) 2-2	Bayern (A) 0-3	Frankfurt (H) 1-5	Bochum (A) 0-4	Other 30 (median)
Leverkusen build-ups reaching final third	30%	26%	51%	52%	56%
Their high pressures that won the ball within 5s	20%	15%	20%	21%	14%
...and kept it (their own possession within 5s)	12.5%	13.5%	15.7%	6.5%	5.3%
Their xG from possessions won in Leverkusen's half	1.32	0.50	1.05	0.17	0.31
Their pressures in Leverkusen's defensive third	40	52	51	77	35
Leverkusen open-play xG	1.37	0.54	0.99	1.83	1.51
Leverkusen exits played long	24%	15%	32%	21%	15%

- **Bayern** stopped the build-up at source and kept the ball when they won it. At home they turned regains into 1.32 xG.
- **Frankfurt** kept the ball most often after winning it, but Leverkusen went long over them (32% of exits). Frankfurt held them below their usual open-play xG but still lost 1-5, to two penalties and clinical Leverkusen finishing.
- **Bochum** pressed twice as often as the typical opponent and won the ball as often as Bayern (21%), but kept it only 6.5% of the time. Leverkusen won it straight back and played through them: 1.83 open-play xG.

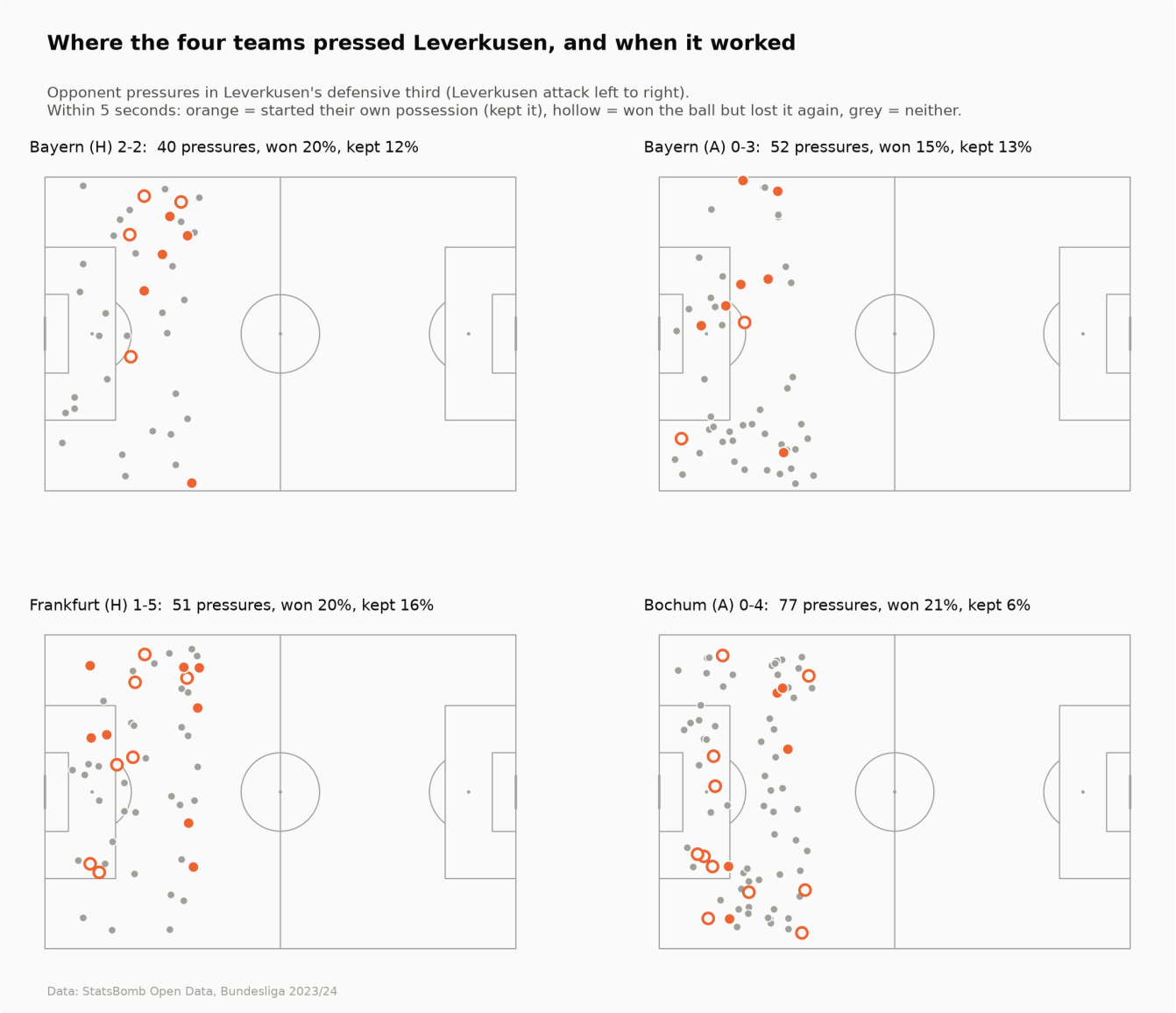
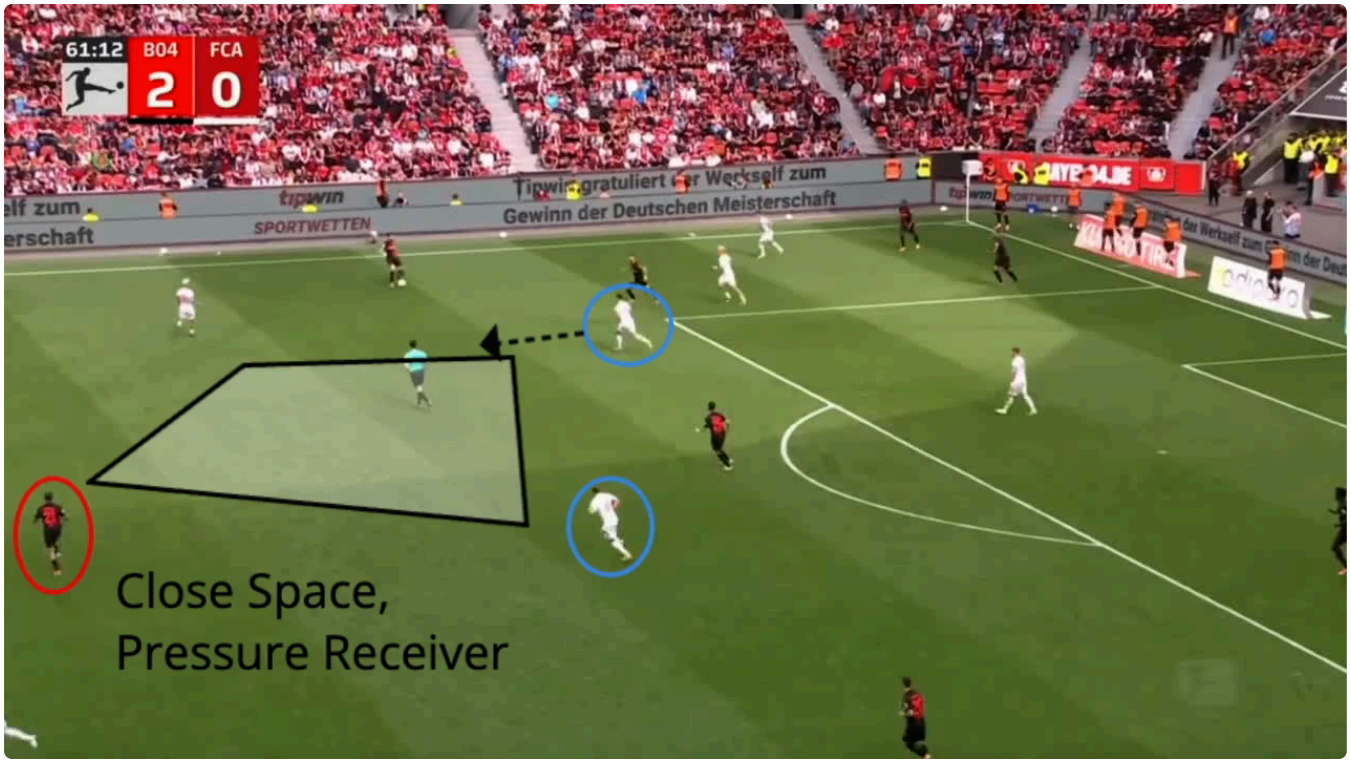


Figure 4. Where the four case-study teams pressed, and whether they won and kept the ball.



Video A. Augsburg (A) 1-2, 61:12. Augsburg close the space and press the receiver in Leverkusen's half; Kömür scores 9 seconds later.



Video B. Bayern (H) 2-2, 80:09. Sané wins the ball and drives into space instead of forcing a pass: winning it is half the job, keeping it is the other half.

Don't judge a press by the score: in Bayern (A) 0-3, Bayern lost but held Leverkusen to their lowest final-third rate of the season.

Who to press and where to block passes

Block passes into Xhaka (a player stands between the ball and him, and gets within 6m if he receives), stop the centre-backs carrying, and press Boniface, Hofmann and Tella when they receive in their own half (Frimpong only with cover).

Xhaka. From 1,959 receptions with player-position data:

Nearest opponent when Xhaka receives	Receptions	Next action plays 10+ yards forward	Next action loses the ball
Under 3m	401	3.5%	5.0%
3-6m	859	3.6%	0.5%
Over 6m	699	16.3%	0.1%

Keeping someone within 6m of him is enough to stop his forward passing (the gap is 12.7 points; 90% interval 9.5 to 16.0). Getting tighter than 3m adds turnovers but is hard to keep up. No opponent managed it for a whole match, including Bayern (his median space against them was 4.7-4.8m, about his usual 4.5m).



Video C. Freiburg (H) 2-3, 28:19. A Freiburg player stays close to Xhaka and blocks the pass into him, so Leverkusen have to go round.

Players not worth pressing once they have the ball (they rarely lose it): Xhaka (loses it 7% of the time), Stanišić (8%), Palacios (9%), Tah and Tapsoba (9%). With Xhaka, stop the ball reaching him instead. Tapsoba and Hincapié also carry the ball forward well when

pressed late, so step onto them early, before they can carry.

Players to press: Boniface (loses it 23% of the time when pressed in his own half), Tella (18%) and Hofmann (17%) lose it most and rarely play forward. Frimpong also loses it often (20%), but plays forward when he escapes, so press him only with cover.

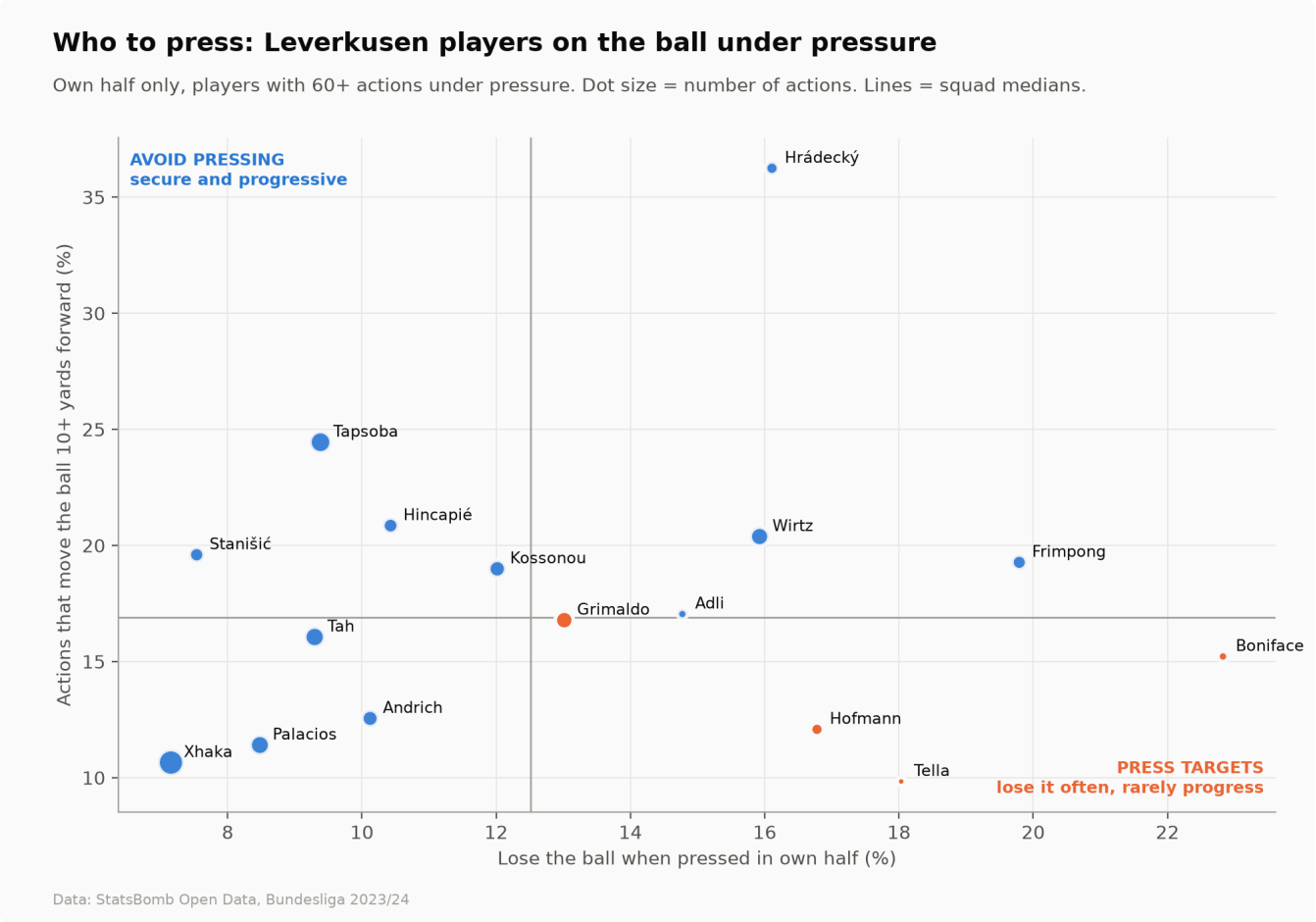
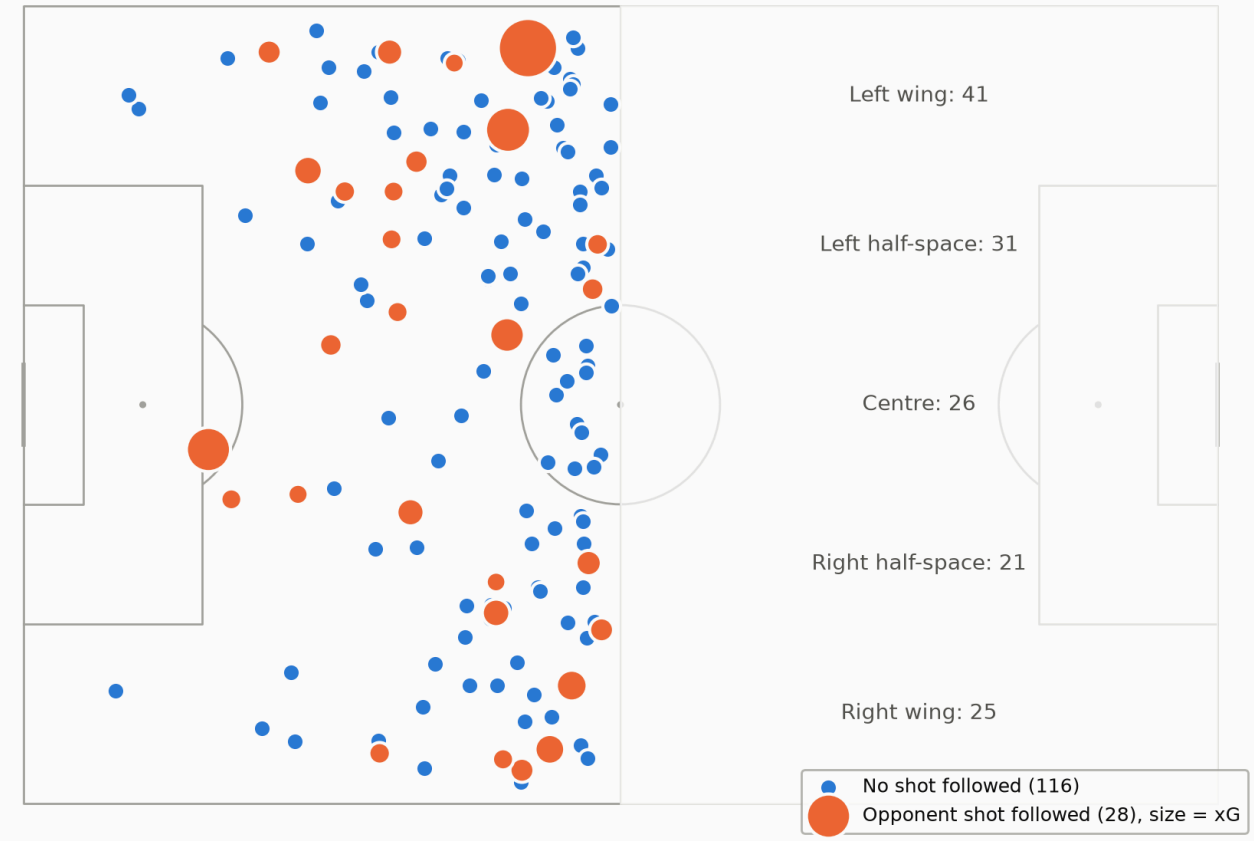


Figure 5. Leverkusen players under pressure in their own half: how often they lose the ball vs play forward.

Where they give it away: 144 open-play turnovers in their own half after build-ups, 28 of which led to an opponent shot (3.3 xG over the season). Their left wing had the most (41), against 25 on the right. Wirtz (18), Hrádecký, Grimaldo and Xhaka (14 each) gave it away most, mainly because they have the ball most.

Where Leverkusen gave the ball away in build-up

144 open-play turnovers in their own half after build-ups from the defensive third (opponent xG: 3.3).
Most often lost by: Wirtz 18, Hrádecký 14, Grimaldo 14, Xhaka 14, Tapsoba 13. Attacking left to right.



Data: StatsBomb Open Data, Bundesliga 2023/24

Figure 6. Where Leverkusen gave the ball away in build-up, and which turnovers led to shots.

The risk of pressing high

Pressing high is safe while the score is level. Over the season it gave up 8.1 xG and won 3.3, but most of that cost came when opponents were chasing the game. At level scores the press roughly broke even.

Of 1,121 Leverkusen build-ups, 419 were pressed high (at least one opponent pressure in their defensive third).

	Not pressed high	Pressed high
Got out of their own third	94%	81%

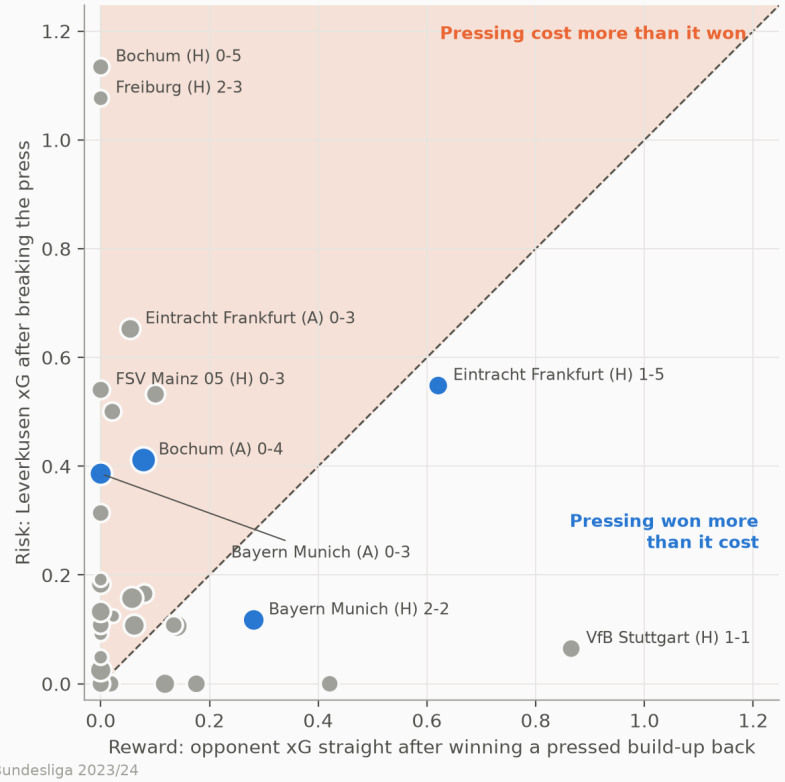
	Not pressed high	Pressed high
Reached the final third	60%	45%
Lost the ball in their own third	2.6%	4.8%
xG per 100 build-ups, once out of their third	1.80	2.39

Pressing slows them down: 15 points fewer build-ups reach the final third (90% interval 9 to 20 points). When they do beat the press, their chances look more dangerous, but this is not proven: the gap in the last row has a 90% interval of -0.4 to +1.7 xG per 100, and at level scores it reverses.

Per match, the press won more than it gave away in 9 of 34 matches and cost more in 22; the other 3 produced no chances either way. The clearest wins were Stuttgart (H) 1-1 (+0.80 xG), Darmstadt (H) 0-2 (+0.42) and Bayern (H) 2-2 (+0.16). Bochum (H) 0-5 was the worst case, but Bochum were down to 10 men from the 14th minute.

Over the season, pressing Leverkusen high gave up 8.1 xG and won 3.3

One dot per match (opponent's view: venue and score). Dot size = number of pressed build-ups. Blue = case-study matches.
Most of the gap came when Leverkusen were already leading and opponents were chasing the game (see the game-state chart).



Data: StatsBomb Open Data, Bundesliga 2023/24

Figure 7. Per match: what pressing high won vs what it gave up.

Split by the score when the build-up started:

Score	Pressed build-ups	Won (xG per 100)	Gave up (xG per 100)	Final-third reach: pressed vs not
Level	173	1.4	1.2	38% vs 60%
Leverkusen leading	210	0.3	2.8	50% vs 59%
Leverkusen trailing	36	0.8	0.9	47% vs 70%

- **At level scores the press broke even** (it won 0.3 xG more than it gave up over the season; the 90% interval runs from 2.5 more to 2.1 less, so treat it as even) and cut their final-third entries by 22 points. Taking out spells after red cards changes nothing; all five red cards in these matches were shown to opponents.
- **The cost came when Leverkusen were already ahead** and opponents were chasing the game: 5.8 of the 8.1 xG given up.

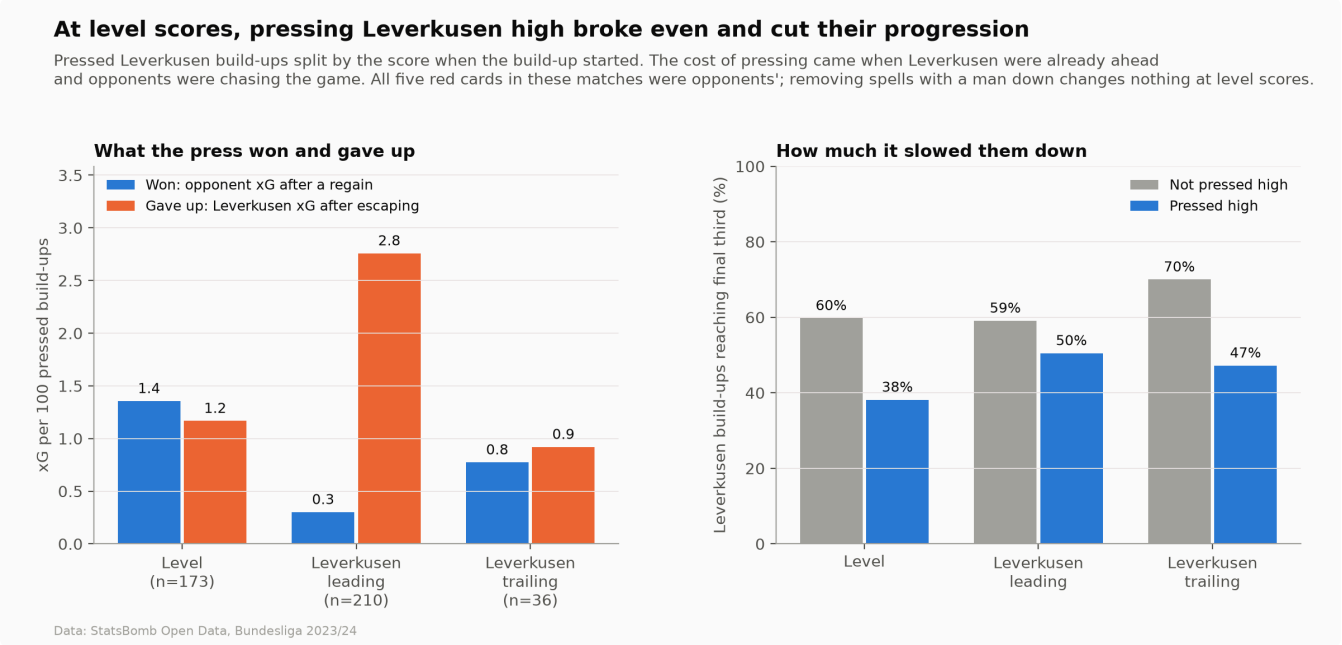
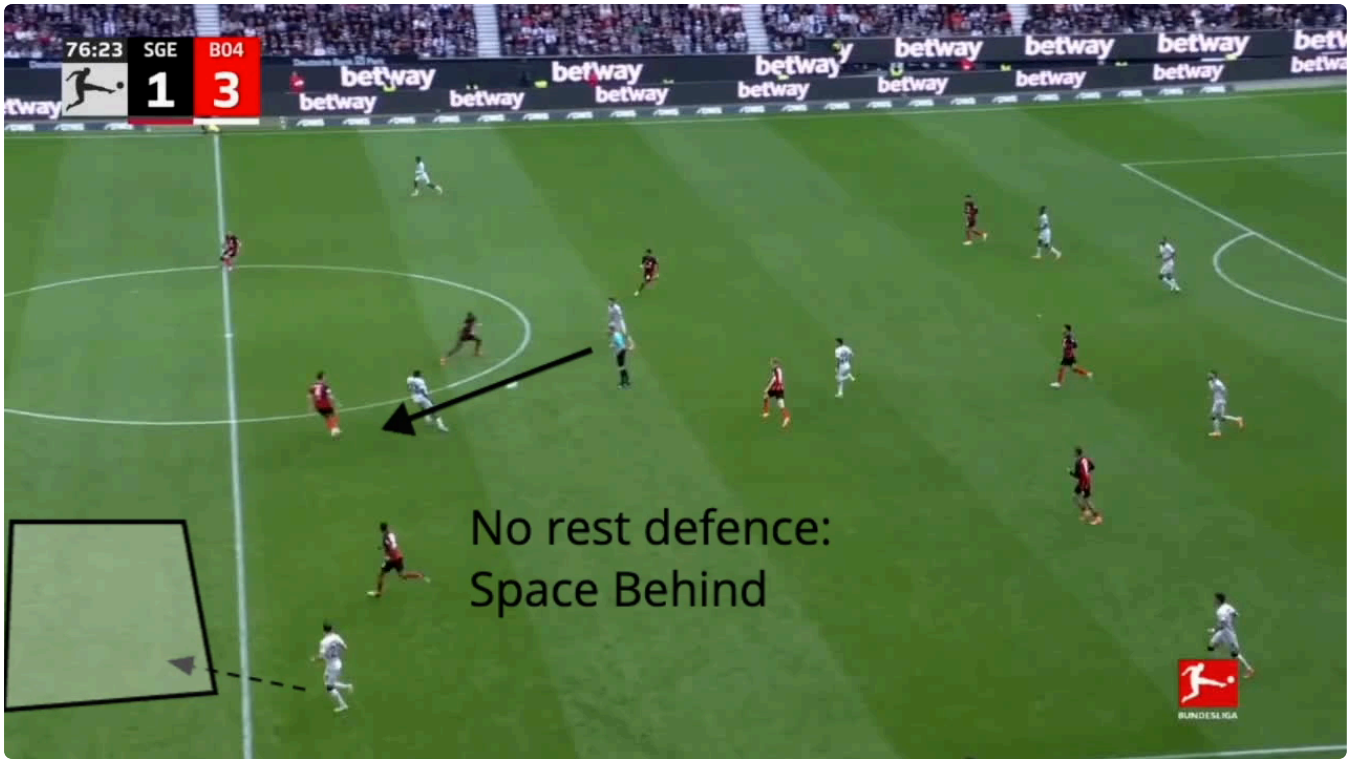


Figure 8. Pressing risk and reward, split by the score.



Video D. Frankfurt (H) 1-5, 76:23. Chasing at 1-3, Frankfurt commit forward with no rest defence; the press is beaten in four passes and Frimpong arrives unmarked.

Why they score so many late goals

Not luck, and not because they won more set pieces: matches opened up late as opponents chased the game, and Leverkusen kept the quality to punish it.

The numbers. Leverkusen scored 18 goals from the 80th minute and conceded 3, and in second-half stoppage time scored 8 and conceded none. Those late goals won them 12 points. They were behind at some point in 7 matches and lost none of them (2 wins, 5 draws).

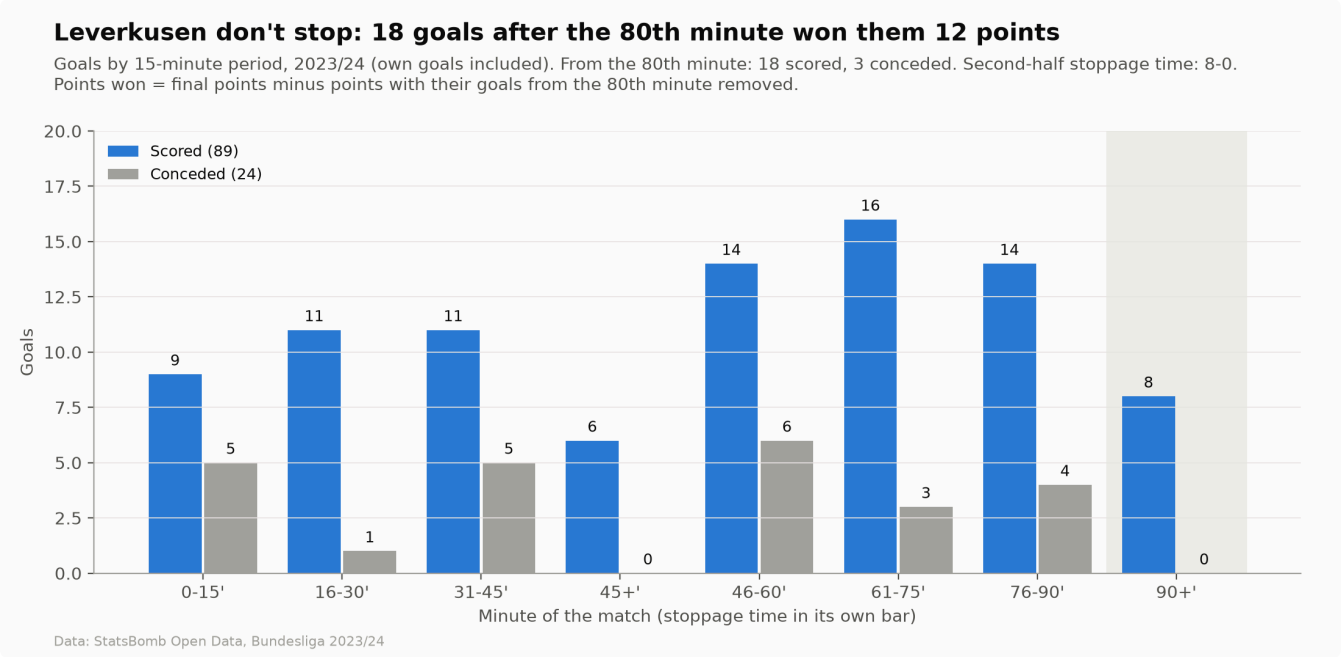


Figure 9. Goals scored and conceded by 15-minute period.

What changed from the 80th minute:

- **Opponents were usually chasing.** Leverkusen were already ahead for about three-quarters of the play from the 80th minute.
- **Opponents pushed up but pressed less.** They defended 9% further from their own goal but made 15% fewer pressures per 90: higher up the pitch, but less pressure on the ball.
- **Leverkusen's chances got better.** Their open-play xG per 90 rose 26% and their xG per open-play shot 12%. Opponents' own xG did not rise (-3%): they opened up without creating more.
- **Not luck.** 18 goals from 14.5 xG is a similar edge over xG to the rest of their season (68 goals from 58.2 xG, own goals excluded).
- **Not more set pieces.** They won 10.4 corners and attacking free kicks per 90 late, against 10.3 earlier.
- **Substitutes.** Subs scored 9 of the 18 and were involved in 11, while playing 34% of the late minutes. That is above their share, but not conclusive (about a 12% chance by luck alone).

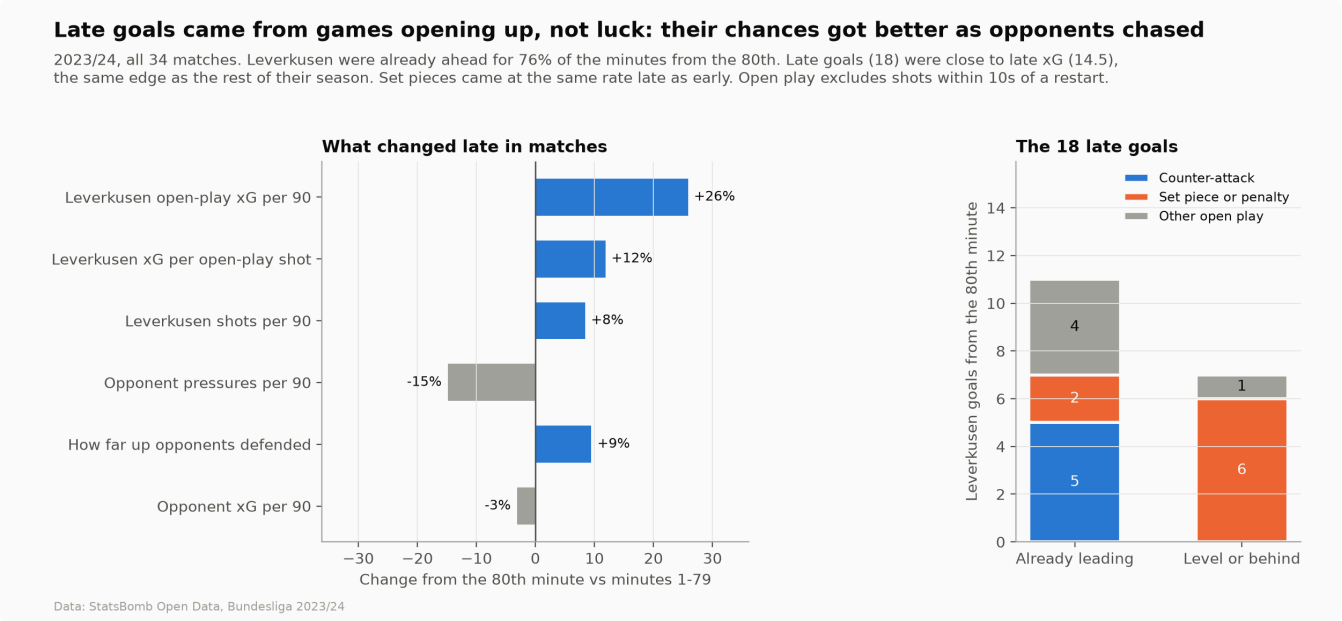
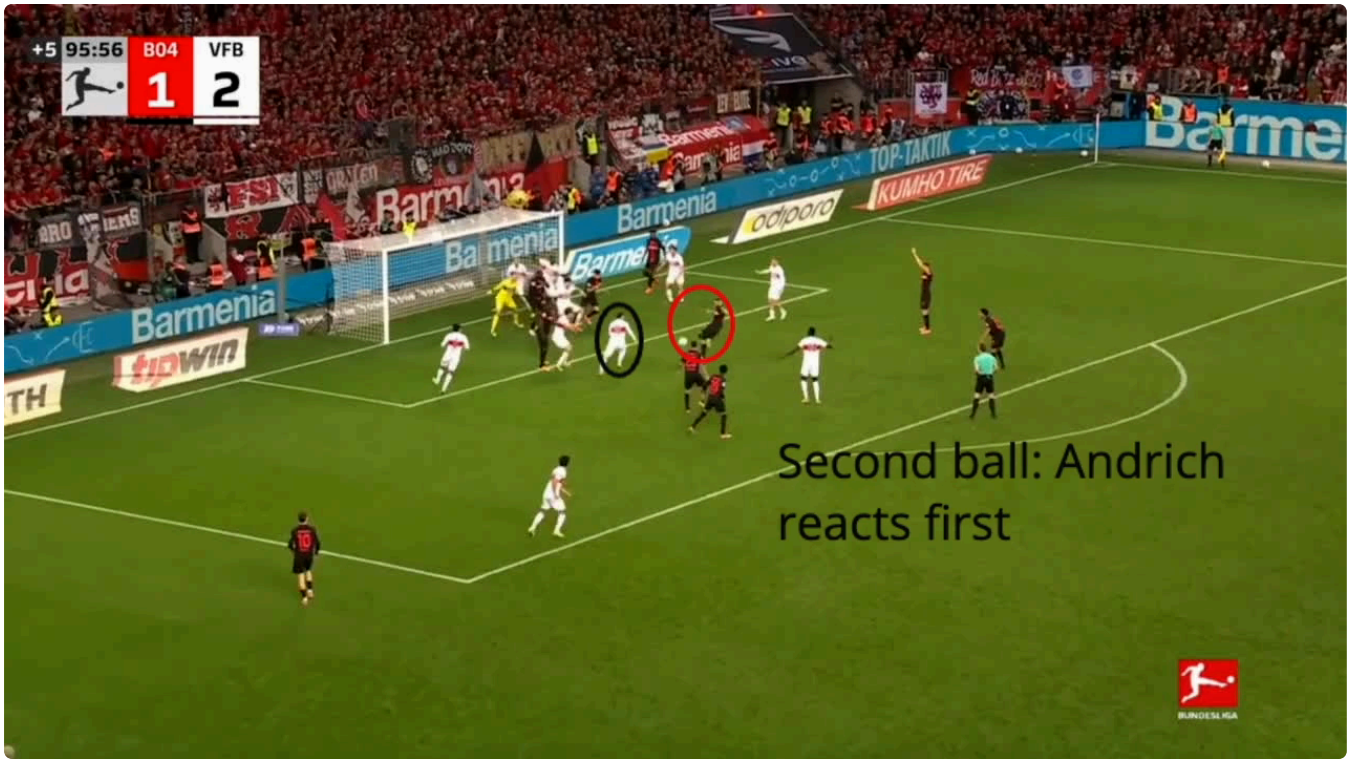


Figure 10. What changed from the 80th minute, and how the 18 late goals came.



Video E. Dortmund (H) 1-1, 96:50. Ten Dortmund players are in the box and three surround Stanišić, yet he still wins the first contact at the near post.



Video F. Stuttgart (A) 2-2, 95:56. Stuttgart clear the free kick, but Andrich is first to the second ball and scores.

Two kinds of late goal:

- **When already ahead (11 goals):** 5 counter-attacks against teams pushing forward. These made scorelines bigger rather than changing results.
- **When level or behind (7 goals):** 6 came from set pieces or penalties (3 corners, 2 free kicks, 1 penalty). These are the goals that directly changed results.

What this means for us:

1. **If we are chasing late, keep a rest defence.** Leave enough players behind the ball to stop the counter: teams that pushed forward without cover conceded on the break.
2. **If we are protecting a result, the danger is set pieces.** Keep set-piece concentration to the final whistle and avoid fouls near the box.
3. **Plan our own late substitutions.** Fresh legs to keep pressing and to match their bench.

18 goals is a small sample, and the 7 result-changing goals especially. Treat these as patterns to check on video, not certainties.

How to attack them

Carry the ball out of their press, attack the flanks rather than the middle, and treat set pieces as our best chance.

Their press. Leverkusen press high: 34% of their pressures come in the opponent's defensive third (against 19% for the teams they played). Per 90 minutes, Adli (25 pressures), Wirtz (24) and Hofmann (22) lead it. Their counter-press: after losing the ball they win it back within 5 seconds 18.5% of the time, rising to 22% in the final third.

Image — Who leads Leverkusen's press per 90 minutes, and their counter-press by zone

Figure 11. Who leads Leverkusen's press (per 90 minutes), and their counter-press by zone.

Getting out. Only 40% of opponent build-ups from their own third reached the final third. Carrying the ball out worked best: carries reached the final third 63% of the time, short passes only 47%.

Image — Opponent exits from their own third against Leverkusen, valued with Expected Th…

Figure 12. How opponents got out against Leverkusen's press, valued with Expected Threat.

Where they concede. From 293 non-penalty shots (27.8 xG):

- **Set pieces:** 8.7 xG (31%) and 10 of the 24 non-penalty goals they conceded (shots within 10 seconds of a corner, free kick or throw-in).
- **The flanks:** 76% of open-play attacks that ended in a shot went through a wide channel in Leverkusen's half, carrying 82% of the open-play xG. Attacks through the middle were worth 0.075 xG each, against 0.10-0.12 down the flanks (90% interval for the gap: 0.004 to 0.063 xG per attack).
- **No weak side:** Frimpong's side (5.2 xG) and Grimaldo's side (5.1 xG) gave up the same. Attack the space behind either wing-back.
- **Rarely caught from deep:** counter-attacks starting in the opponent's own third produced only 1.2 xG all season; attacks after winning the ball in midfield produced 4.8.

Image — How chances against Leverkusen started, and which way open-play attacks came

Figure 13. How chances against Leverkusen started, and which way open-play attacks came.

With the ball:

1. Centre-backs step out with the ball, or play longer past Wirtz and Hofmann; avoid short passes in front of their press.

2. Once through, attack down either flank; don't force it through the middle.
3. Secure the first pass after winning the ball in their half, because they counter-press hard there.
4. Rehearse set pieces: they produced 10 of the 24 non-penalty goals Leverkusen conceded.

Game plan

Press high while the score is level, drop into a compact block when chasing, and block passes into Xhaka at all times.

Moment	Instruction	Evidence
Their goal kick / keeper has it	Level score: press high and block passes into Xhaka. Chasing the game: hold a compact block, don't commit everyone.	At level scores the press broke even and cut final-third entries from 60% to 38%; when chasing, it gave up 2.8 xG per 100 pressed build-ups
Build-up in their third	No.10 or striker blocks passes into Xhaka and stays within 6m of him at all times.	His forward passing drops from 16% to under 4%
Centre-back on the ball	Step onto Tapsoba or Hincapié before they carry; let Tah have it square.	Carries out are more dangerous than short passes; 78% reach the final third
Ball goes wide	Pressing trigger: jump together and use the touchline as an extra defender. Target Boniface, Hofmann and Tella when they receive facing their own goal; press Frimpong only with cover behind.	Wide exits are their least dangerous; these players lose it most under pressure
Inside channels	The two central midfielders block passes into the left half-space and centre.	Left half-space exits carry the most threat
Wirtz drops short	Central midfielder follows him; don't let him turn.	Against Bayern, Wirtz dropped in to rescue the build-up

Moment	Instruction	Evidence
Press is broken	Recovery: back line drops and holds, nearest midfielder delays, no diving in.	Half the xG they made after breaking a press came within 15 seconds
Set pieces and the last 10 minutes (80th minute on)	Defend every set piece to the final whistle: win the first contact at the near post, react first to the second ball, no fouls near the box. If chasing, keep a rest defence behind the ball.	Their 18 goals from the 80th minute won them 12 points; 6 of the 7 that changed a result came from set pieces or penalties (Video E, F)

Watch on video before training: Bayern's two matches (how they pushed play away from Xhaka and onto Tapsoba) and Bochum (A) 0-4 (why they gave the ball straight back after winning it).

Methods and limitations

Data: StatsBomb Open Data, Bundesliga 2023/24: all 34 Leverkusen matches, event data plus 360 freeze frames (positions of visible players at each event). Code: Python with statsbombpy and mplsoccer.

Definitions

- **Build-up:** a Leverkusen possession that started in their defensive third (first 40 yards), excluding corners and kick-offs.
- **Pressed high:** at least one opponent pressure in Leverkusen's defensive third during that build-up.
- **Won the ball:** a ball recovery, won interception or won tackle within 5 seconds. **Kept it:** StatsBomb opened a possession for that team within 5 seconds, which requires control of the ball.
- **Expected Threat (xT):** each zone's probability of leading to a goal, fitted on these 34 matches. An exit's value is the xT added over the rest of that possession.
- **Open play:** excludes penalties and shots within 10 seconds of a restart. StatsBomb tags a whole possession by how it started; we use the 10-second rule instead, so a goal 20 passes after a throw-in counts as open play here.
- **Game state:** the score when a build-up started, rebuilt from goals and own goals; it matches the official result in all 34 matches.

- **Uncertainty:** 90% intervals (the range the true value very likely sits in) come from a bootstrap that resamples whole matches 2,000 times. A claim whose interval crosses zero is reported as not proven.
- **Units:** pitch distances are StatsBomb yards (120 x 80); 360 distances are converted to metres. Pressing volume is per 90 minutes, from line-ups and substitutions.

Limitations

- This is a past season. Personnel and coaching may have changed; treat it as a model of how to approach a team like this.
- Observational data: the risk numbers are split by game state, but opponent quality is not controlled for, and the level-score sample (173 pressed build-ups) leaves wide intervals.
- 360 frames only show players in camera view, so the nearest opponent can be missed.
- The case study is four matches; single-match xG numbers are small and noisy. Trust the season totals more.
- Video review covered the key findings (Video A–F); the other points rest on the data alone.
- Video A–F are stills from broadcast footage, reviewed against the event data. They illustrate the findings; the numbers come from the data.